

THE ROBERTSON REPORT

Concerned over the multiple lines and administrations that had come about, the Government of India requested the British Government to send an expert to advise on the situation. Of these, the Robertson Report is revealing for its time period. Sir Thomas Robertson, the expert, spent months travelling across the country on an all-expenses-paid visit and submitted, what historian JN Westwood calls, was an “ill-written string of platitudes”. Lord Curzon, the Viceroy of India (1899–1905), cancelled his passage home and made him rework the report. The results are quite astonishing. In 1902, there were about 41,000 km in operation. Of this, the Government was financially responsible for around 32,000 km, but controlled about 9,600 km. His recommendations led to the formation of an early version of the Railway Board in 1901.